From the era of horizontal screens to the era of vertical screens, the possibility of Chinese micro-dramas going global

1. Introduction:

In recent years, the Chinese streaming platforms, Reelshot, which is targeted at micro-dramas, goes viral and quickly enters overseas media markets, influencing the global communication structure of streaming platforms. As a new trend, micro-dramas are usually shot and shown in vertical format with each episode last for a few minutes, featuring user-generated content, fragmentation and wish-fulfillment story. In this genre, viewers can enjoy appealing shot story with dramatic plot twists and fast-paced narratives that revolve around revenge or betrayal. From horizontal screens to vertical screens, it changes not only the size and direction of the screen, but the audiences' viewing situations and time, especially the fragmentation time. Moreover, as a kind of combined medium, the streaming platforms of micro-dramas create a new medium infrastructure that caters for current consumption habits. According to statistics from a forum held recently in the 2nd Beijing Internet Audiovisual Arts Conference, the domestic market for micro dramas reached 37.39 billion yuan ($5.31 billion) in 2023, marking a sizable surge of 267.65 percent year-on-year (Ji, 2024). Thus, Chinese micro-dramas industries are thriving and enjoying the widespread support.

This essay will combine uses and gratifications theory (UGT) and cultivation theory to discuss the motivation of this new trends and analyze the possibility of micro-dramas going global. UTG can persuade people to get involved in the

propaganda of micro-dramas and cultural promotion. And cultivation theory will stimulate the spread and popularity of this kind of media form. The integration of these two theoretical frameworks promotes our understanding of the potential of micro-dramas. UGT mainly addresses the issue: why people choose to watch micro-dramas and how to persuade people to subscribe and purchase micro-series, while cultivation theory is associated with the spread of culture and how micro-dramas cultivate audience's perception of China.

2. Literature review:

2.1 Uses and gratifications theory (UGT)

Uses and gratifications theory focuses on media users' psychological needs, which lead to their different media uses, resulting in gratifications of needs (Katz et al., 1973). In this theory, media users, who are assumed to have specific purposes and use different media to suit for their needs, are active, selective and can decide what to see on media. In other words, various types of media compete against each other to gain viewers' attention or cater for viewers' needs. Therefore, if the media can give media users more gratifications, it will be used more often and be more popular. UGT also provides a basis for examining why users adopt the new media and is applied to explain why people tend to use a specific medium to satisfy their needs (Kaur et al., 2020).

The global popularity of Chinese micro-dramas could be explained by UGT. Micro-dramas feature high-energy and plot-twisting storytelling, which fulfills the fragmented entertainment demands of global audiences. Viewers can experience

sweets and bitters in one episode. Therefore, the twisting points make Chinese micro-dramas stand-out and appeal to global audience by providing different emotion experiences. According to the UGT, these feel-good micro-dramas can meet personal integrative needs and strengthen confidence through making people think from the main character's perspective and acknowledging them they are good. Especially for the zero-to-hero narratives and domineering CEO romance drama, these stories can easily meet media users' psychological needs and build a fantasy world where people can be destined lover of the overbearing tycoon at his first glance or a versatile person with lots of skills and excellent friends. On this ground, people will be willing to release their pressure by watching micro-dramas, which can also lessen their awareness of the self and satisfy their tension-free needs. Like vlogs, micro-dramas with vertical screens create more immersive experience than horizontal screens, adding more psychological dependence. Besides, according to Wang & Tchernev's typology, social needs, one of the psychology needs, can be satisfied through chatting about the content of the series and guessing what will happen next (Wang et al., 2012). Sometimes, the end of one episode is a turning point that arouses our curiosity, creating topics and stimulating the desire to purchase. Streaming platforms can not only provide entertainment, but enable people to discuss episodes, share memes and create fandom communication community, fostering community engagement and catering to social gratifications through self-expression. Thus, through streaming platforms' global broadcast, micro-dramas can increase cultural diplomacy and cultural promotion. Furthermore, in the digital era, people cannot leave phones and

may have habitual needs of scrolling through short videos or mini-dramas to fill their spare moments of fragmented time. And short episodes fulfill the need for convenience in an era of fragmented attention spans, where audiences often consume media during short breaks. To conclude, based on UGT, Chinese micro-dramas meet people's psychological needs from various aspects and will appeal to more and more viewers to watch, chat about and purchase it.

Q: What specific gratifications do international audiences seek and derive from watching Chinese micro-dramas?

2.2 Cultivation theory

Cultivation theory examines the long-term effects of television viewing on viewers' conceptions of social reality (Stack et al., 2015). Based on what George Gerbner found in 1960s, the media consumers who spend more time consuming media are more likely to see the "real world" in terms of the images, values, and ideologies that emerge through the lens of media (Gerbner & Gross, 1976). Thus, media can influence viewers' perception of the world: more exposure people have, more influential the media will be. Besides, Gerbner proposed The Mean World Syndrome, which refers to the phenomenon that heavy viewers are influenced by the distorted world in media and are more likely to perceive the real world as a more dangerous or disappointing place. Besides, through mainstreaming effect, viewers who have different opinions or attitudes may be changed by constant exposure to repeated symbols or ideas on media. More importantly, once people who shape the initial perception, if they have the similar experiences, the cultivation effect will be

stronger, strengthening the mean world syndrome and expanding the scope of mainstreaming. Therefore, the power of media is unpredictable and can not only influence people's perception of the world, but cultivate people's understanding of culture.

Chinese micro-dramas feature low cost and quick production, which makes global audience easy to get access to these series. Through social and streaming platforms' promotion, media users will have repeated exposure to micro-dramas, influencing their perception of Chinese culture. Especially for breaking the global market through the mode of combing local performers and production with domestic technology dominance polish your language, viewers' acceptance and appropriation in the identification process and engagement with media content lead to favorable attitudes toward the target culture, ultimately reinforcing positive convictions and attitudes regarding the culture in question (Tirasawasdichai et al., 2022). Moreover, according to a CGTN report in 2024, Reelshot amassed nearly 19 million global downloads across all platforms in 2023 and generated more than $22 million in revenue. Therefore, the growing popularity of Chinese micro-dramas can be an indicator of the increasing transmission of Chinese cultural value, ideas, attitudes and perspectives. For instance, Chinese micro-dramas often present idealized versions of Chinese life, fostering international audiences' positive perceptions of China, enhancing soft power and arousing foreigners' curiosity about Chinese life. However, Chinese micro-dramas face "adaptation" challenges when going overseas. On Reelshot, based on existing IP of online wish-fulfillment stories and satisfying genres,

it generates alternative satisfaction for viewers and adapts to local condition by translating local culture. For instance, altering from the theme of the domineering CEO and revenge to Vampire and Werewolf, it not only caters to the local audiences with familiar themes, but also features a storyline with ups and downs that is different from European and American stories. Take *Alpha's Daughter* for example, the story explores themes of acceptance, love, and the bond between two individuals who are destined to be together, transcending the boundaries of their species. These dramas are stereotypical, but feature stylish male and female leads, as well as humorous and comedic elements, catering to local media consumption. But, a blog, posted on The World of Chines in 2024, investigates the opinion on Chinese micro-dramas and someone said, "they were created with what they think the foreign market wants". Hence, there are still limitation and issues during the spread of Chinese micro-dramas. In conclusion, based on cultivation theory, through a polished version of Chinese life, Chinese micro-dramas can influence global audiences' perceptions of China.

Q: What Chinese culture and societal values do micro-dramas transmit to the international audiences?

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